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Fearless Commissar

By Jeemon Jacob



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Left politics has given this country many a stalwart, and one entered his 100th year this October 23. Velikkakathu Sankaran Achuthanandan (VS), the former Kerala chief minister and only surviving member of the 32 founders of the Communist Party of India (Marxist), or the CPI(M), achieved the distinction quietly, surrounded by family members in state capital Thiruvananthapuram. A stroke in October 2019 has robbed the veteran Communist of voice, and movement, and fear of infection has restricted the entry of visitors. But eager wellwishers wait outside every morning to catch a glimpse of their leader when he sits in the verandah of his son's house. In hometown Punnapra in Alappuzha district, a flex was raised to greet him on his birthday and *kheer* distributed to mark the occasion. Governor Arif Mohammed Khan sent his wishes, so did Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, with whom VS has had a difficult relationship over the years.

He was a born survivor, taking charge of his life after losing mother Achamma at age four, and father Sankaran seven years later. Dropping out of school, he joined his elder brother's tailoring unit as a helper and then left to become a coir mesh worker. He joined the Congress in 1938, and the Communist Party of India two years later, inspired by the revolutionary P. Krishna Pillai. He was the Alappuzha district secretary when he was made campaign convenor for the Devikulam bypoll in 1958 and the party won. This cemented his reputation in the party. He also had a five-and-a-half-year stint in jail, for taking on the then diwan of Travancore, C.P. Ramaswami Iyer.

His journey from an ordinary party worker to becoming a leader with a mega following, cutting across party affiliations, is a testament to his sheer determination and political conviction.

"VS inspired Kerala to learn green politics, fight consumerism and 'deviations' in the Communist movement, sensitised people about gender politics and took on the tormentors of women and children, all in his own style," recounts A.G. Sasidharan, who served as his private secretary for 10 years. "He became very popular among the masses as leader of the Opposition in 2001. He was 78 then and still travelled across the state raising volatile issues like corruption in the UDF ministries led by A.K. Antony and Oommen Chandy, built a fan base cutting across party lines and age groups, and prepared the battleground for the LDF to come to power in 2006," adds the 72-year-old, who retired as an additional secretary. For Sasidharan, his mentor's greatest achievement has been the ability to remain a member of the party despite several provocations and conspiracies to cut him down.

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"We will not have another leader of his calibre in Kerala," says a CPI(M) youth leader. "A fighter to the core, he never made compromises and took up issues that no other leader in Kerala addressed."

Having spent a long time in the CPI(M), VS commands a unique position in the party. He became a member of the secretariat of the undivided Communist Party in 1957 and was CPI(M) state secretary from 1980 to 1992. He was elected to the legislative assembly in 1967, 1970, 1991, 2001, 2006, 2011 and 2016, and was leader of the Opposition from 1992-95 and 2001-06. He served as the chief minister of the state from 2006 to 2011 and was chairman of the Kerala Administrative Reforms Commission from 2016 to 2021.

"VS should not have accepted the chair of the Administrative Reforms Commission when the party denied him the chief minister's post in 2016," says a senior CPI(M) leader. "He made compromises with Pinarayi and the party to get a post of cabinet rank. Unfortunately, he has not communicated with the people since then. His family members and the party have conspired to keep him silent for the rest of his innings in politics." But then VS has already achieved enough. ■